START FROM SCRATCH / HYPER-PACED LEARNING

Week 1: AI fluency and mental models

Before building with AI, learn how to collaborate with it deliberately. This first week establishes the judgment, clarity, and responsibility that will guide every later build.

01
CHOOSE
Decide where AI helps.

02
GUIDE
Give it useful context.

03
JUDGE
Remain accountable.

What AI fluency means

AI fluency is the ability to work with AI in ways that are effective, efficient, ethical, and safe. It is not a collection of prompt tricks. It is a repeatable practice of making sound decisions before, during, and after an AI interaction.

The human stays in the loop

AI can generate options, patterns, and drafts. You retain responsibility for the goal, the context, the evaluation, and the decision to use the output.

A foundation for every later week

The 4Ds will reappear as you make model calls, ground answers with RAG, and design agents with tools and guardrails.

The question is not “Can AI do this?” The better question is “What should AI do here, what should I decide, and how will I know the result is safe to use?”

THE 4D FRAMEWORK

Four connected habits for working with AI

Anthropic’s AI Fluency Framework describes four competencies. They work together - not as a checklist completed once, but as a cycle of intentional collaboration.

Delegation	Set the goal. Decide whether, when, and how AI should contribute - and what must remain a human decision.	**Ask:** What is the job? What should AI do? What should it not do?
Description	Provide enough context, constraints, examples, audience, and output format for useful behaviour.	**Ask:** What does a good answer look like? What must the AI know?
Discernment	Evaluate the output and the process critically for accuracy, usefulness, relevance, and limitations.	**Ask:** Is this correct? What evidence supports it? What needs checking?
Diligence	Take responsibility for ethical, safe, transparent use of AI and for anything you choose to share or act on.	**Ask:** Is this safe to use? What should be disclosed? Who is accountable?

Explore the source material: Anthropic - AI Fluency: Frameworks and Foundations

WAYS OF COLLABORATING

Automation, augmentation, and agency

The 4Ds apply whether AI completes a specific task, collaborates with you as a thinking partner, or carries out a configured task more independently.

Automation	Augmentation	Agency
You specify a task and AI carries it out. Example: turn notes into a first draft.	You and AI work iteratively, each contributing judgment and ideas. Example: refine a plan through dialogue.	You configure AI to work toward a future task with defined knowledge, tools, and boundaries. Example: an agent that triages an incident.

A good collaboration loop

1. Delegate
Choose a useful role for AI.

2. Describe
Add context and success criteria.

3. Discern
Check the output and reasoning.

4. Act with diligence
Use, revise, disclose, or reject.

Do not treat AI output as a final answer simply because it is fluent. Treat it as material you are responsible for assessing.

PRACTICE THE 4Ds

Bring one real task to AI

Choose a task you genuinely need to complete. The aim is not to write the most elaborate prompt; it is to design a responsible collaboration.

1. Delegate What part of the task will AI help with? What stays with you?	**2. Describe** What goal, context, audience, constraints, and format will you give it?
3. Discern How will you test the output for accuracy and usefulness?	**4. Diligence** What privacy, attribution, safety, or approval considerations apply?

Ready-to-discuss questions

- What did you delegate to AI - and why was that the right boundary?
- What changed when you added useful context and clear success criteria?
- What did you choose not to accept or use, and how did you decide?

AI fluency is the foundation for building. The next week turns this judgment into your first model call.